AFT PROGRESSIONS & REGRESSIONS

ANYTIME FITNESS

Moving well is essential not just for gym performance, but for meeting the ever-changing demands of everyday life. Whether lifting a toddler, carrying groceries, standing up from a chair, or rotating to check a blind spot, our ability to move efficiently and adapt to different loads, angles, and environments directly impacts our strength, mobility, and long-term resilience.

The six foundational movement patterns—Push, Pull, Hinge, Squat, Lunge, and Rotation—form the basis of nearly every physical task we perform. Mastering and progressing these movements isn't just about lifting heavier weights; it's about building the adaptability to handle real-world challenges safely and effectively.

Understanding the complexity of movement means recognizing that no two days feel exactly the same. Fatigue, stress, injuries, or external demands can impact how well we move, making it crucial to adjust movement difficulty dynamically—not just for performance goals, but to maintain functional independence and prevent injury as life throws new demands our way.

By strategically progressing or regressing movements through load, tempo, range of motion, and body position, we create a training framework that helps individuals build strength where they need it, reinforce stability where they lack it, and develop movement confidence for both training and daily life. The ability to scale exercises ensures that everyone—regardless of age, experience, or ability—can train safely, make progress, and stay prepared for whatever life requires.

AFT Progressions & Regressions Principles

Train for Life, Not Just the Gym

- Movement quality comes first—before load, intensity, or complexity. The goal is not just strength in the gym but **resilience in daily life.**

Empowerment Through Adaptability

- Regaining mobility, stability, and strength allows people to **move with confidence** in any scenario—whether lifting a barbell or carrying a child. Progressions expand possibilities, ensuring clients feel **capable, not restricted.**

Function Over Formula

- We progress or regress movements based on **how they help people feel, function, and perform in the real world.** By adjusting **load, tempo, ROM, and stability**, we meet clients **where they are today** while guiding them toward **long-term success.**

The High Five Assessment

This screen evaluates core stability, lower-body mechanics, and overall coordination by testing five fundamental movement patterns:

Perform 5-10 reps per movement (per side if applicable).

Overhead Squat	Split Squat	Single-Leg Balance Reach	Plank	Birddog

For each of the five movements, you'll record:
•Pain/Functionality Score: 0 to 3, using the following key:

0 = Pain is indicated (movement cannot be continued or is very uncomfortable)	1 = Movement is dysfunctional or cannot be completed	2 = Movement is functional but with clear compensations	3 = Movement is functional without noticeable compensation

Why This Matters

The High Five Assessment provides a **real-time snapshot** of where a client is on the **movement continuum**, allowing coaches to **place them on the appropriate regression or progression ladder quickly**.

This ensures safe and effective programming that **meets them where they are** while guiding them toward **long-term improvement.**

High Five (EXAMPLE)

Movement	Pain (Y/N) Y=1	R Score	L Score	Lowest Score	Notes
Overhead Squat	N	–	–	3	Good depth, stable spine
Split Squat	N	2	1	1	Left knee collapse on reps
Single-Leg Balance Reach	N	1	2	1	Right hip drop under fatigue
Plank	N	–	–	2	Hips sag slightly at 20s
Bird Dog	N	2	2	2	Slight rotation in torso
Sum	–			9	
Overall Score (Sum/5)	--			1.8 avg	

A result like this indicates a need to regress or refine unilateral leg work (Split Squat, Single-Leg Balance Reach) and address some core stability issues (Plank, Bird Dog).

How to Interpret & Apply the High Five Scores

Identify Patterns in Scores

Overhead Squat (3) → Strong, no major mobility/stability limitations.

Split Squat (1) → **Left knee collapse** indicates potential **hip/knee instability or quad dominance.**

Single-Leg Balance Reach (1) → **Right hip drop under fatigue** suggests lateral instability.

Plank (2) → **Hips sagging at 20s** may indicate **core endurance** limitations affecting full-body control.

Bird Dog (2) → **Slight rotation in torso** signals **weak anti-rotation control.**

Actionable Takeaways

Unilateral Stability Needs Work → Low Split Squat & Single-Leg Balance Reach scores indicate the need for **regressions** and **gradual strength progressions** before advancing to deeper lunge variations.

Core Stability Deficit → Plank & Bird Dog scores suggest **weak trunk endurance & anti-rotation strength**, which may impact heavier lifts.

Strengths vs. Weaknesses → Overhead Squat shows **good mobility & posture**, but **localized stability issues** need targeted improvements.

Adjust Programming

Regress Unstable Patterns:

Split Squat → Suspension **Assisted or Box-Supported Lunge**

Single-Leg Balance Reach → **Use Hand Support or Reduce Range of Motion**

Improve Core Stability:

Plank → **Introduce Shorter, High-Quality Holds with Tension Cues**

Bird Dog → **Add Band Resistance to Improve Anti-Rotation Control**

Progress Load & Complexity Gradually:

Continue working **bilateral patterns** (Squat, Deadlift) while **gradually building unilateral strength** to **bridge the gap**.

Applying the High Five

•Efficient Evaluations
•Screens multiple planes, upper/lower-body strength, stability, and core control in under 10 minutes.

• Immediate Feedback
•Clients quickly identify movement limitations, such as: "I can't hold my plank past 20 seconds without sagging."
•"My left knee collapses during a split squat."

Real-Life Application
These tests reflect essential movement patterns used in daily life, including squatting, stepping, bracing, and coordinating limbs effectively.

Overhead Squat & Split Squat:
Evaluates thoracic and shoulder mobility along with core control under load.

Low Scores indicate difficulty maintaining a neutral spine in hinge-based lifts.

Recommended adjustments: Start with supported or lower-depth variations to reinforce stability before progressing.

Single-Leg Balance Reach:
Assesses unilateral stability and proprioception.
A score of one or two suggests single-leg RDLs may be too advanced at this stage.

Recommended adjustments: Begin with two-legged variations, partial range of motion, or suspension assistance before advancing.

They may start with two-legged variations and build single-leg capacity over time with partial-range or TRX support.

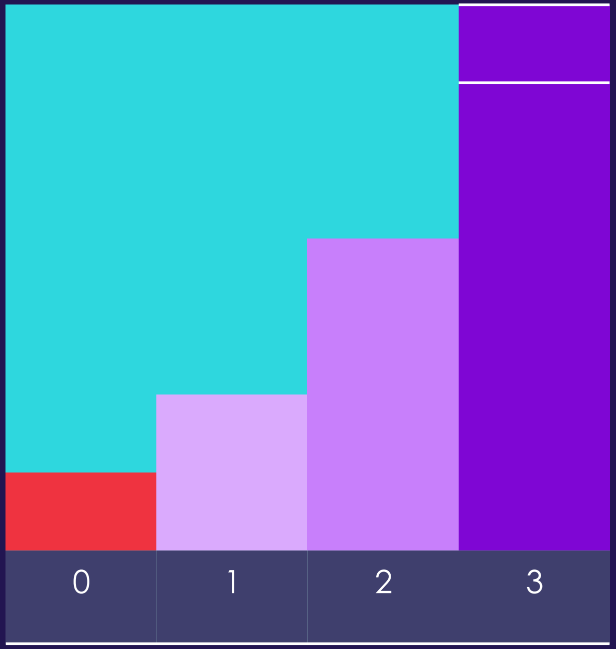
Plank & Bird Dog:
Measures core endurance and anti-rotation control.

Scores of one or two indicate weaknesses in bracing, which can impact hinge and pressing stability.

Recommended adjustments: Start with glute bridges, partial-range RDLs, and pull-throughs before advancing to heavier barbell lifts.

The **High Five Assessment** creates a clear roadmap for each client, connecting movement scores to specific regressions or progressions. This approach ensures that clients train pain-free, build strength effectively, and develop long-term movement confidence.

Placing Clients on the Progression Continuum



Interpreting Scores & Immediate Actions

Scores of 0 or 1 (Pain or Dysfunction)

•**Action:** Use a **regression** or **limited ROM** for that pattern.
•**Example:** If an Overhead Squat scores a **1**, modify to a **Box Squat or Goblet Squat to a higher box** to reduce strain.
•**Why It Matters:** Pain or an inability to complete the movement means focusing on **range, stability, and motor control** before adding complexity.

Scores of 2 (Functional with Compensation)

•**Action:** Use a **baseline** variation, but monitor form and adjust with minor tweaks.
•**Example:** A **heel lift for squats** can assist someone struggling with ankle mobility.
•**Why It Matters:** A **2** suggests the movement is possible but includes compensations (e.g., **knee valgus, slight torso collapse**). A mindful warm-up and **corrective work** can refine mechanics.

Scores of 3 (Functional without Compensation)

•**Action:** Introduce a **progression** if it fits their goals, or stay at baseline based on mesocycle planning.
•**Example:** Moving from a **Goblet Squat to a Front Squat** or from an **Incline Push-Up to a Standard/Weighted Push-Up**.
•**Why It Matters:** A **3** indicates readiness for **increased load or complexity** while maintaining movement integrity.

Blending Progressions & Regressions in a Single Session

Clients may have **different scores across movement patterns**.
•Example: A client scores a **3 on Bird Dog** (strong trunk control) but a **1 on Overhead Squat**.
•Solution: **Progress their core work** while using a more conservative **squat variation**.

Why This Matters: Progressions and regressions are **not fixed categories**—they adapt **day-to-day** based on movement readiness, ensuring **safe, scalable improvements for every client.**

Recall that each High Five assessment is rated on a scale of 0–3 for functionality (0= Pain).

One Continuum, Multiple Entry Points

A single **progression continuum** allows every client to train at the right level while keeping the group **on the same page**. Each session follows a **central movement theme** while adjusting difficulty based on **individual performance**.

Coach Demonstrates the Baseline Variation

•**Explain & Demo:** Start by demonstrating a **moderate-intensity movement** (e.g., Goblet or Landmine Squat).
•**Key Cues:** Neutral spine, braced core, and knees tracking over toes.

Layer in Regressions & Progressions

•After establishing the baseline, briefly **demonstrate modifications** to fit different abilities.
•Example:

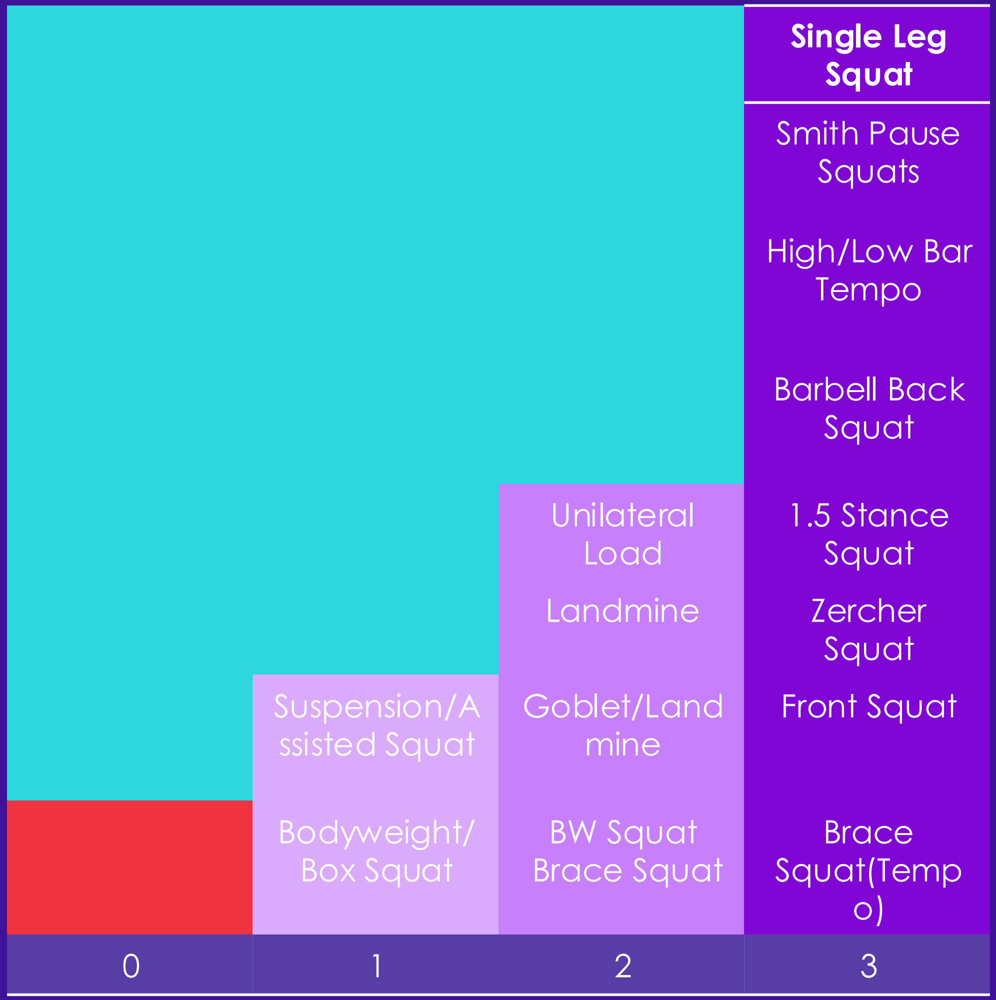
- "If you struggled with Overhead Squat, try a **Box Squat** to limit range or add support."
- "If you feel strong and stable, move to a **Front Squat** with light load."

All Clients Remain on the "Same Page"

•Although participants may perform different squat variations (Box vs. Goblet vs. Front Squat), they are **united by the same movement theme**:

- *"We're all squatting right now."*

•This approach maintains **class flow, reduces confusion, and allows coaches to correct individuals effectively** without disrupting the session.



ANYTIME FITNESS

AFT MOVEMENT PATTERN CONTINUUM

Horizontal Push

BENEFITS:

Develops upper-body pushing strength
Improves shoulder and chest musculature
Enhances core stability when performed with proper bracing (e.g., push-ups). *Upper-body pushing strength is critical for daily activities like pushing doors, lifting objects, or maintaining shoulder health and posture. Stability in pressing movements prevents compensations that can lead to shoulder strain.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Pectoralis major, anterior deltoids, triceps brachii

			Resistance (Chaos) Unilateral Load (Unstable) Add Rotation
			Unilateral Load (Stable)
		Unilateral Load (Stable)	Ring/Suspension Push Up
		Barbell Bench Press	Barbell Floor Press
	DB Chest Press Kneeling Push Up	Dumbbell Chest Press	SA Dumbbell Chest Press
	Wall Push Up Incline Push Up	Push Up Resistance Push Up	Resistance Push Up Suspension Push Up (Tempo)
0	1	2	3

If a client scores low on Bird Dog/Plank (1 or 2), they likely need a more stable pressing position like a bench press or incline push-up to reinforce core control.

Vertical Push

BENEFITS:

Builds overhead strength and shoulder stability Improves scapular upward rotation (healthy overhead mechanics) Reinforces core engagement under a vertical load. *Overhead pressing is essential for real-world tasks like lifting objects onto shelves, stabilizing loads overhead, and maintaining strong, mobile shoulders. Proper execution prevents compensations that stress the lower back or rotator cuff.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Deltoids (especially anterior/lateral), upper trapezius (stabilizer), triceps brachii

0	1	2	3
	Seated DB Press Banded Overhead Press Wall Overhead Press	Unilateral Load (Stable) Standing SA OHP Unilateral Load SS or CL) HK/TK SA DB Press	Unilateral Load (Unstable) Add Rotation Unilateral Load (Stable) Handstand Push Up BB Strict Press Barbell Push Press Landmine DBL DB OHP

If a client scores low (1-2) on Overhead Squat or Bird Dog, they may lack the thoracic mobility or core control needed for strict pressing. Start them with **seated or kneeling variations.**

Hinge

BENEFITS:

Strengthens the posterior chain to prevent low-back injuries Trains safe hip-dominant movement patterns for lifting objects off the ground Builds powerful glutes and hamstrings, enhancing athletic performance. *A strong hinge pattern is essential for real-life tasks like picking up heavy objects, jumping explosively, or preventing low-back injuries by training hip-driven movement instead of lumbar compensation.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Gluteus maximus, hamstrings, erector spinae (core stabilizers)

0	1	2	3
			Add Rotation
			Barbell Deadlift
		Banded Hip Thrust	Unilateral (Single Leg DL/Bridge)
		KB Swing	Goodmorning(Heavy)
	Banded Pull Through	Deadlift from Box	Trap Bar
			Sumo
	Glute Bridge (Supine on Floor)	Goat Belly Banded Hip Thrust	RDL Conventional

A client scoring low (1-2) in Bird Dog or Plank may struggle with core bracing in hinge movements. They should start with ***glute bridges, banded pull-throughs, or box-supported deadlifts*** *before progressing.*

Squat

BENEFITS:

Enhances lower-body strength and hypertrophy Boosts functional mobility (e.g., getting up from a chair) Strengthens knee and hip extensors for daily tasks and athletic performance. *Squatting is one of the most fundamental human movement patterns, essential for daily tasks like sitting, standing, lifting, and athletic performance. Strengthening the squat improves lower-body power, joint health, and injury resilience.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Quadriceps, gluteus maximus, adductors; core stabilizers support the spine

			Smith Pause Squats
			High/Low Bar Tempo
			Barbell Back Squat
		Unilateral Load	1.5 Stance Squat
		Landmine	Zercher Squat
	Suspension/Assisted Squat	Goblet/Landmine	Front Squat
	Bodyweight/ Box Squat	BW Squat Brace Squat	Brace Squat(Tempo)
0	1	2	3

A client scoring low (1-2) on Overhead Squat may struggle with depth and stability. They should begin with a ***box squat or brace squat*** *before progressing.*

Horizontal Pull

BENEFITS:

Strengthens the upper back for better posture Improves scapular retraction and shoulder stability Balances out pressing movements to reduce injury risk. *Pulling movements are essential for maintaining **posture, shoulder stability, and spinal alignment.** Strengthening the upper back counteracts pressing movements, preventing imbalances and reducing injury risk.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Latissimus dorsi, rhomboids, trapezius (mid/low), posterior deltoids, biceps

0	1	2	3
			Pendlay Row
			Barbell Bent Over Row
			SA/SL Row
		2/3 Pt Row	Seal Row (Supported)
		Low/ Mid- Angle Row	Landmine Row
	Cable/ Banded Face Pulls	Sandbag Bent Over Row (Multiplanar)	Inverted Row (Tempo)
	Machine Seated Row (Back Support)	Seated/ Suspension Row	Unilateral DB/KB Bent Over Row (Unsupported)

*A client scoring low (1-2) on Bird Dog or Plank may struggle with core bracing in unsupported rowing positions. They should begin with a **machine row or supported row** before progressing.*

Vertical Pull

BENEFITS:

Increases upper-back strength for better posture and shoulder health Develops grip strength and core stability (especially in pull-ups/chin-ups) Complements pressing movements by maintaining balance in the shoulder girdle. *Vertical pulling is essential for real-world tasks like climbing, carrying, and overhead lifting. Developing grip strength and core control enhances total-body stability and pulling power.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Latissimus dorsi, biceps brachii, forearms, scapular downward rotators (rhomboids, lower traps)

0	1	2	3
			Unassisted Pull Up
			Chin Up/ Assisted Pull Up
			Negative Chin Up
			Upright Row
		Assisted Pull Ups	Pull Overs (Tempo)
	Pull Downs (Tempo)	Pull Overs	Lat Pull Downs (Heavy + Tempo)
	High Angle Cable Row	Lat Pull Down	Scapular Pull Up

*A client scoring low (1-2) on Bird Dog or Plank may struggle with core engagement in pull-ups. They should begin with **lat pull-downs or assisted variations** before progressing.*

Lunge

BENEFITS:

Develops unilateral strength and corrects side-to-side imbalances Improves hip stability, knee tracking, and balance Great for daily activities like climbing stairs or picking items off the ground. *Unilateral strength is critical for everyday movements like climbing stairs, stepping onto curbs, or navigating uneven terrain. Training lunges improves knee stability, hip strength, and balance for long-term mobility and injury prevention.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Quadriceps, gluteus maximus, hamstrings (stabilization), calves; core aids balance

			Assisted SL Squat/ Pistol Squat
			Single Leg Box Squat (Loaded)
			BW Single Leg Squat
		Forward/ Walking Lunge	Goblet SS/ Reverse Lunge (Heavy)
		Goblet SS/ Reverse Lunge (Light + Tempo)	Front Foot Elevated SS
	Assisted Reverse Lunge	BW Reverse Lunge	Goblet SS/ Reverse Lunge (Heavy)
	Assisted Split Squat	BW Split Squat	Bulgarian SS
0	1	2	3

*A client scoring low (1-2) on Single-Leg Balance Reach may struggle with stability in a lunge. They should begin with **assisted split squats or reverse lunges** before progressing.*

Rotation

BENEFITS:

Develops core stability and rotational strength (essential for many sports and daily twisting movements) Improves trunk control, reducing spinal stress in rotational tasks Enhances overall athleticism and injury resilience. *Rotational strength is essential for daily life (twisting to grab objects, sports movements, and core bracing under load). Training rotation improves power transfer, injury resilience, and overall functional strength.*

PRIME MOVERS:

Obliques (internal/external), transverse abdominis, spinal rotators; hips often assist

0	1	2	3
			Zercher Rotations
			KB Rotations (Single Leg)
			KB Rotation (TK/HK)
		Med Ball Rotational Throws	Thoracic Pull Through (Loaded)
		Standing Cable Rotation	Windmill (Top/Bottom)
	HK Pallof Press	Standing Pallof Press	Landmine Rotation/ Russian Twist
	TK Pallof Press	TK Cable Rotation (Light)	SL/SA Cable Rotation

*A client scoring low (1-2) on Bird Dog or Plank may struggle with rotational stability. They should start with **Pallof Press variations** before progressing.*

Aligning the Small Group mesocycle to the Progression Continuum

Weeks 1-2: Build the Foundation

•Focus on **baseline movements** (box squat, RDL, push-up variations).
•Prioritize **technique, control, and stability** before adding complexity.
•**High Five Guide:** Clients scoring **1s & 2s** should reinforce foundational patterns.

Weeks 3-4: Progress with Stability

•Increase **range, load, or tempo** while refining movement efficiency.
•**High Five Guide:** Clients improving to **2s & 3s** can advance to goblet squats, hinges, or split squats.

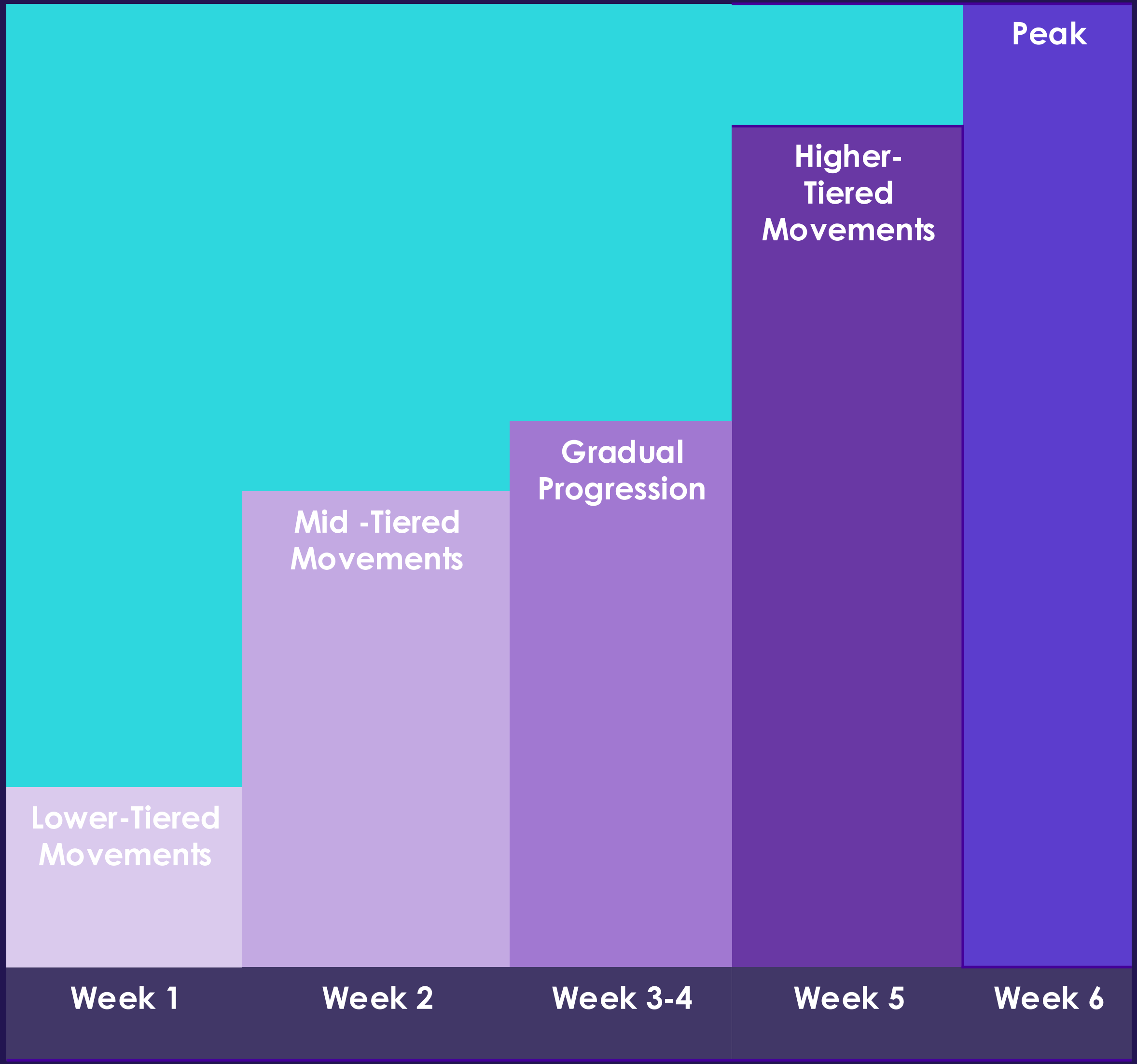
Weeks 5-6: Strength & Complexity

•Introduce **higher loads, unilateral work, or advanced variations** (barbell squats, RDLs, weighted lunges).
•**High Five Guide:** Clients scoring **3s** can push intensity, while **lower scores** require volume/intensity adjustments.

Cycle Reset & Reassessment

•**Re-test using High Five.** Improved scores → progress movement options.
•If movement remains limited, **adjust reps, tempo, or exercise selection** to reinforce control.

You can map each phase to the **progression continuum** as follows:
This cyclical approach ensures **long-term, structured** progression without skipping essential fundamentals.



Bringing It All Together: Navigating the Continuums

- **1. One Continuum Per Pattern**
- Each foundational movement (Squat, Hinge, Lunge, Push, Pull, Rotation) follows a **progression ladder**.
- In Team settings, demonstrate **1–2 baseline variations**, then direct individuals to their appropriate level.

- **2. Daily Readiness & Auto-Regulation**
- **Ask Clients How They Feel:** Fatigue, stress, or soreness may require a slight regression (e.g., Goblet Squat → Box Squat).
- **Check Movement Quality:** If form breaks down, **adjust immediately**. If technique is solid, **invite them to try the next level**.

- **3. Mesocycle Progression**
- **Start at a Manageable Level:** Begin each **4–6 week cycle** with a baseline assessment.
- **Gradual Advancement:** Progress by **moving up the continuum** or adjusting **load, tempo, or volume**.
- **End-of-Cycle Assessment:** Use the **High Five Screen** or **in-app Strength Assessment** to reassess and determine the next phase.

Bringing It All Together: Driving Long Term Success

- 1. Micro-Progressions: Adjusting Acute Variables
- **Load:** Increase resistance (kettlebell, dumbbell, barbell) without altering movement.
- **Volume:** Add reps or sets while maintaining movement quality.
- **Tempo:** Slow eccentrics or add pauses to build strength at the current level.
- **Range of Motion:** Gradually deepen squats or extend lunge/hinge distance as mobility improves.

- 2. Communication & Coaching
- **Empower Clients:** Teach self-assessment (e.g., adjusting movements based on how they feel).
- **Coach Oversight:** Ensure **strict form** before progressing; hold borderline cases at their level.
- **Celebrate Small Wins:** Progress isn't just new exercises—it's mastery of existing ones.

- 3. Scaling in a Group Setting
- **One Theme, Multiple Levels:** Everyone is "squatting," but one person may be at a Box Squat (Level 2) while another is at a Back Squat (Level 3).
- **Simple Flow:** Demo a **baseline movement**, a **regression**, and a **progression**, then guide choices based on daily readiness and High Five scores.

Adjusting Acute Variables by Consumer Type

Progression isn't just switching exercises—it's tweaking key variables to challenge movement effectively.

Load	Load refers to the **amount of external resistance** applied to a movement (e.g., bodyweight, dumbbells, kettlebells, barbells, bands)				
Volume & Rest	More sets, higher reps, or shorter rest intervals escalate difficulty without a new exercise.	**Strength Focus: Lower reps, higher sets** (4-6 reps, 4-5 sets, longer rest)	**Hypertrophy (Muscle Growth): Moderate reps, moderate sets** (8-12 reps, 3-4 sets, moderate rest)	**Endurance & Work Capacity: Higher reps, shorter rest** (12-20+ reps, 2-3 sets, short rest)	**Decrease Rest Intervals →** Less recovery, higher intensity
Tempo **(Ex. 4-2-1-0)**	**Tempo:** Modify movement speed for control and strength development.	**Eccentric (Lowering Phase)** → Slower for strength	**Pause (Bottom/Top Position)** → Increases time under tension		**Concentric (Lifting Phase) →** Explosive for power Pause (Top Position)
Range of Motion	**Range of Motion (ROM)** refers to the extent of movement through which a joint travels during an exercise.	**Partial-Range** (Box Squat) → Shortens ROM for stability	**Full-Range** (Goblet Squat) → Standard movement pattern	**Extended-Range** (Deficit Deadlift) → Deepens ROM for mobility	**Assisted ROM** (Suspension Split Squat) → Supports control and stability
Body Position	**Body position** refers to how a client's stance, limb placement, or external support influences movement difficulty.	**Base Adjustments:** Stance width, foot position, bilateral/unilateral work		**Angle/Support Changes:** Low/high angles, kneeling, supine, quadruped, standing	

Instead of "Beginner/Intermediate/Advanced" workouts, **use a single continuum** guided by High Five scores to **customize movement intensity for each client.**

SUMMARY

1. One Continuum, Multiple Entry Points

•Each movement pattern has a structured **progression/regression ladder**, making on-the-fly adjustments seamless.
•Clients can move **up or down the ladder** based on readiness, ensuring appropriate challenge levels.

2. The High Five Assessment as Your Compass

•**Establish Baseline:** Overhead Squat, Split Squat, Single-Leg Balance, Push-Up, Plank/Bird Dog guide daily movement capacity.
•**Immediate Adjustments:** Real-time feedback determines the **best movement variation** without rewriting workouts.

3. Tracking Progress on the Continuum

•**Celebrate Milestones:** Guide clients to recognize progress—e.g., moving from assisted to full push-ups or from a KB hinge to a barbell deadlift.
•**Adjust Acute Variables:** Volume, load, and tempo tweaks enhance progression even within the same movement.

4. Sustainable Growth & Long-Term Success

•**Autoregulation:** A client excelling in Week 3 might need a **deload in Week 5**—adjusting regressions **isn't a setback; it's smart coaching.**
•**Peak Safely:** As the mesocycle progresses, keep clients engaged, safe, and progressing **without burnout.**

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